

Cover story TELEVISION

on to their heads on Colors's *Balika Vadhu*, and on Star Plus's new show, *Mitwa... Phool Kamal Ke*, turmoil erupts in a village when a high caste girl falls in love with a low caste boy.

If that's not alarming enough, in a universe where 90 per cent of the homes have one TV set, there's more to come. Rahul Mahajan will be looking for the perfect wife on NDTV Imagine; 10 young men and their mothers will be looking for a wife from among five women in the Indian version of the *Perfect Bride* on Star Plus; 13 WWE wrestlers will be pitted against 13 Indian wrestlers in four matches in every episode of *100 per cent Lucha*, a fusion of fiction and reality on Colors; while on Discovery Travel and Living, Shah Rukh Khan will allow cameras to stay with him for a new six-part series. Clearly, India is ready to live with the paradox of soaps that deify conservatism and reality shows that defy it. Or it may well be as sociologist Shilpa Phadke says, that pushing back the boundaries of what is acceptable is spawning anxieties resulting from the negotiations around being global and Indian at the same time.

Either way, after eight years of *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*-induced slumber, the viewer is awake, and the channels are trying to smell the coffee. Every Wednesday when the Television Audience Measurement ratings are released for the week before, there is a frantic post-mortem across India's burgeoning General Entertainment Channels (GEC). The battle is for the hearts and minds of the 113 million Hindi-speaking viewers who form the largest chunk in the TV universe, currently pegged at Rs 24,000 crore, including subscription revenue. In the past 18 months, four Hindi GECs have been launched. Colors, having spent Rs 100 crore on carriage fee to cable operators, has zoomed, NDTV Imagine is trying to dust itself while 9X and Real have failed to pick up the pieces. The Turner-Miditech

BHASKAR PAUL



AGLE JANAM MUJHE BITIYA HI KIJO ZEE TV

It pulled Zee TV out of its dark night. So what that the show itself is bought and sold to produce male heirs. The show debuted on

FASHION FIX

If saas-bahus are out, so are their chandelier earrings and Swarovski-encrusted kanjeevarams

WILD THINGS Camouflage shorts and wet ganjees might be the survival kit for Sony's *Iss Jungle Se Mujhe Bachao* contestants, but they're also climbing the fashion charts.

THE WHOLE NINE YARDS Rakhi Sawant might be trying hard to be the coy bride in her pop-coloured lehenga cholis, but it's her saris that are sending women to their local tailors. Whether it's the cream sari with gold leaf work teamed with a lame blouse or the chocolate brown one with a red blouse, local boutiques have cuttings pinned up of all. And the biggest surprise, Sawant has been picking up these designs herself from local boutiques.



NEVER SAY SARI Kirron Kher's big screen Punjabi mother is now famous. But it's only as the host of *India's Got Talent* on Colors that her sartorial skills have come forth. Her antique jewellery matches perfectly with her ornate saris which have replaced the western-wear other reality show judges sport.